The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

Paramount looked set to win the race to buy **Warner Bros Discovery**, a rival film studio, after **Netflix** declined to sweeten its bid. Netflix's shares jumped by more than 10% on the news. Warner said Paramount's improved $111bn offer was preferable to the one it had earlier accepted from Netflix, apparently ending a months-long bidding war. Regulators must clear the deal.

Pakistan's defence minister declared "open war" on **Afghanistan** after launching "counter strikes" on Kabul and Kandahar, two Afghan cities. The attacks came in response to Afghanistan beginning "large-scale offensive operations" along the countries' border. The Taliban said their strikes were in retaliation for Pakistani attacks on Sunday. The neighbours agreed a fragile ceasefire in October.

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https://www.reuters.com/world/asia-pacific/pakistan-strikes-afghanistan-targets-clashes-intensify-2026-02-27/

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Update: https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/c0j5qx9n887o

Afghanistan launched “large-scale offensive operations” along its border with **Pakistan.** The Taliban said the strikes were in retaliation against Pakistani attacks on Afghanistan on Sunday. Pakistan said those strikes targeted groups responsible for several deadly attacks on its territory, including a suicide-bombing in Islamabad, the capital, that killed at least 36 people.

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https://www.reuters.com/world/asia-pacific/afghanistan-has-launched-retaliatory-attacks-pakistani-border-posts-taliban-2026-02-26/

https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/2/22/pakistan-carries-out-strikes-in-afghanistan-after-islamabad-suicide-attack

Britain’s Green Party secured a landmark victory in a by-election in Gorton and Denton, a Manchester constituency that had been

held by Labour for nearly a century. Reform UK came second. Both it and the Greens, populist parties from the right and left respectively, had poured resources into the race, sensing the fragility of Labour under its unpopular prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer.

Anthropic said it could not "in good conscience" bow to the **Pentagon's** demand to be granted unfettered access to its AI tools. The firm insists that its Claude AI must not be used for mass domestic surveillance or for autonomous weapons. Pete Hegseth, America's war secretary, gave Anthropic until Friday to relent or risk severe sanctions, including a potential ban on Pentagon's suppliers using Claude.

Hillary Clinton, a former American secretary of state, told a congressional committee that she had no knowledge of crimes committed by **Jeffrey Epstein** and did "not recall ever encountering" the sex offender. She ended her testimony by saying: "I want to see the truth come out." Her husband Bill, a former president who travelled on Epstein's jet but denies knowledge of his crimes, will testify on Friday.

Nuclear negotiations between **America** and **Iran** concluded in Geneva without a deal. Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, described the talks as among the "most serious" yet. The Omani mediator said "significant progress" was made. Further discussions are expected to take place next week. Iran may be playing for time: Donald Trump has suggested America will attack if it does not negotiate a deal.

A court in **Bangladesh** ordered the government to ask Interpol to issue a "red notice" against **Tulip Siddiq**, a British MP. The notice is a call for international assistance in her arrest. Bangladesh accuses Ms Siddiq of using ties to her aunt—Sheikh Hasina, Bangladesh's autocratic former prime minister—to influence a real-

estate deal. Ms Siddiq denies wrongdoing and Britain does not have an extradition treaty with Bangladesh.

Figure of the day: 460,000, the number of graduates produced each year by China's elite "985" group of universities. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

The Clintons' date with Congress

Bill and Hillary Clinton are headed to Capitol Hill. After months of stalling, the Clintons will answer a congressional committee's questions about their ties to Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender. Mrs Clinton, who was Barack Obama's secretary of state, will testify in a closed-door deposition on Thursday. When Mr Clinton follows on Friday, he will become the first former president to testify before a congressional panel since 1983.

Neither has been accused of wrongdoing by Epstein's victims—and they deny any knowledge of his misdeeds. The Clintons' lawyer claims that the committee, which is led by Republicans, is creating "a public spectacle for partisan purposes". Mrs Clinton accuses the Justice Department of "slow-walking" the release of files related to Epstein; she maintains that the Trump administration is engaged in a "cover-up". Expect finger-pointing from all sides, but few revelations.

Photograph: Getty Images

Last chance for America and Iran

The window for diplomacy is closing. Officials from America and Iran will meet in Geneva on Thursday for a third round of negotiations aimed at preventing a war. The meeting comes as a second American aircraft-carrier is deployed near the Middle East. Satellite images show that many of the American warships usually docked in Bahrain are now out at sea. Donald Trump has promised to attack Iran if it does not negotiate a deal—though his objectives remain unclear.

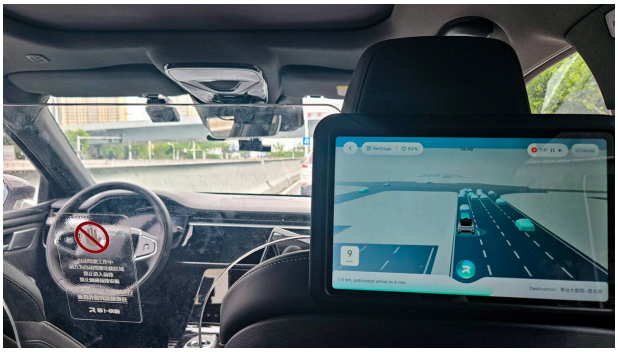
Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, will probably offer concessions on the country's uranium-enrichment programme. Some of Mr Trump's Republican allies want to avoid a deal that boosts Iran's embattled regime. So does Israel. Mr Trump made scant mention of Iran during his state-of-the-union address this week. He said Iran could avoid conflict if it promised not to build a bomb. But Iranian officials have offered similar assurances in the past; repackaging old rhetoric would hardly represent a breakthrough.

Illustration: David Simonds

A test in Manchester for Britain's government

Manchester will be the talk of Westminster on Thursday. Residents of Gorton and Denton, in the city's south-east, are voting to replace Andrew Gwynne, a Labour MP who resigned in January. It should be a safe Labour seat. The constituency had the 38th-largest Labour majority in 2024. Gorton, part of inner Manchester, has a young population and a large group of Muslim voters. Denton, a suburb, is mainly white and working class.

Yet the Labour government's unpopularity opens up opportunities for rivals. Reform UK and the Green Party are pouring resources into the constituency. Opinion polls indicate that all three parties stand a chance. The by-election is especially risky for the prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, who prevented Andy Burnham, the Greater Manchester mayor and a potential rival to lead the party, from standing as the Labour candidate. A Labour loss in Gorton and Denton would be bad for Sir Keir; a victory by Mr Burnham might have threatened him more.



Photograph: IMAGO

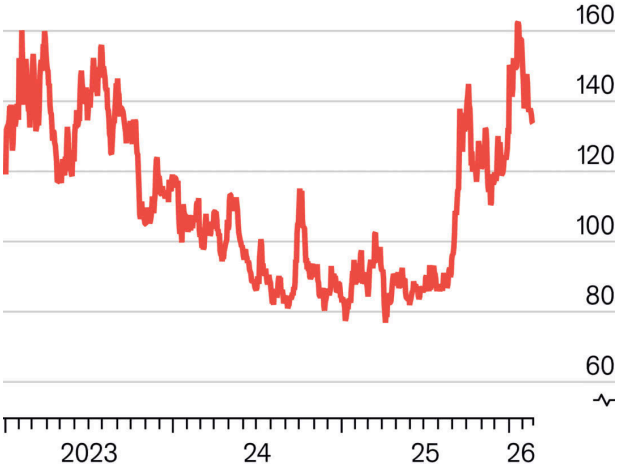
Baidu takes the wheel

Baidu, a Chinese search-engine giant, has a bad reputation at home. Many young Chinese blame it for turning the national internet into an ad-clogged cesspool. They ridicule its apps, which they say are unusable. Although Baidu was the first company to release a Chinese large language model for consumer use, called Ernie, it lags behind those created by competitors such as Alibaba, Tencent and ByteDance, the owner of TikTok.

Yet the picture is not entirely bleak. Baidu's driverless-taxi service, Apollo Go, has been pushing aggressively into foreign countries, most recently Dubai (in partnership with Uber, an American ride-hailing firm). It is also eyeing launches in Britain and Germany (with Lyft, another ride-hailing app) this year. When Baidu reports its full-year results on Thursday, investors will look for signs that China's search-engine titan is now a robotaxi champion-in-waiting.

Picking up speed

Baidu, share price, $



Source: LSEG Workspace

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which prominent scientist, who helped explain that sickle cell anemia was caused by an abnormal protein, became an advocate for taking high doses of vitamin C?

Wednesday: The third Monday of January is a federal holiday named after which civil-rights activist?

Success is having to worry about every damn thing in the world, except money.

Johnny Cash